AKHILESH YADAV
Samajwadi Party leader, in an interview with INDIA TODAY, *March 5, 2012*

"It is only recently that I learnt that Sam Pitroda is a Vishwakarma. Rahul Gandhi says he has been eating food cooked by Dalits. I've been doing that for ages. My cook in Delhi is a Dalit"

confrontation, moral indignation and relentless populism. Once in power, she turned her regional strength into leverage over the UPA government, repeatedly blocking reforms and extracting concessions. Her dominance illustrated how coalition governments at the Centre could be held hostage by state leaders whose primary accountability lay elsewhere, not in national stability but in regional supremacy.

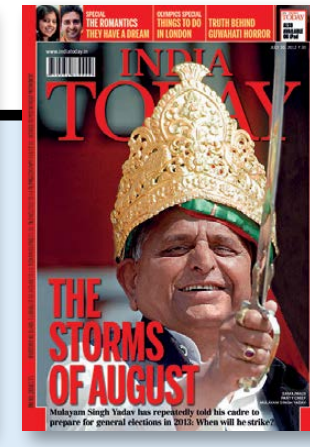
In Uttar Pradesh, BSP supremo Mayawati embodied a different assertion of regional power. Her politics fused identity, symbolism and state authority with unprecedented scale. By translating Dalit assertion into an absolute majority in 2007, she turned social justice into a ruling ideology rather than a bargaining tool. Her ambition to shape national outcomes was never concealed. Uttar Pradesh, under her watch, ceased to be merely a state and became the axis on which the fate of the UPA, Rahul Gandhi's ambitions and coalition permutations turned.

The arrival of Akhilesh Yadav marked a generational recalibration of regional politics. He softened the Samajwadi Party's image, blended welfare with aspirational symbolism and used technology and youth outreach to modernise a party long associated with muscle and nostalgia. His rise showed that regional power was no longer only about identity arithmetic but also about perception, communication and managerial competence.

Alongside these elected leaders were figures who shaped politics without formal authority. Amar Singh was the archetypal power-broker of the era. Fluent in access, deals and backroom negotiations, he became indispensable during moments of crisis, most notably when the UPA fought for survival during the 2008 trust vote. His influence revealed the informal mechanics of coalition politics, where



▲ *Mar. 5, 2012*



▲ *Jul. 30, 2012*

Change of Gear

In the run-up to the 2012 Uttar Pradesh assembly elections, the Samajwadi Party's founder Mulayam Singh Yadav made an unorthodox strategic calculation. Rather than positioning himself to return as chief minister, he anointed his son Akhilesh Yadav, then 38 and party state president, as the face of a campaign aimed at capturing urban youth and recasting the SP's image after a decade in the political wilderness. Akhilesh's energetic campaigning, including a long cycle tour and control over organisational levers, helped propel the SP to a commanding majority, and the junior Yadav became the youngest to hold that office in the state, signifying a generational shift within the party. While subsequent years witnessed factional tussles and electoral setbacks, the transition itself underscored a broader pattern in Indian regional politics where leadership renewal, even within established hierarchies, can reshape electoral coalitions and recalibrate party narratives in the face of rising challengers on the national stage.



REVOLVING RULE UP CM Mayawati in Lucknow, Dec. 2007. Between 2005 and 2015, power in the state swung between her BSP and Mulayam Singh Yadav's SP

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